

A gym membership may not be a luxury: for you, it might be a necessity. If your skin is temperamental, a higher-end moisturiser could be an absolute must. Public transport may not be as realistic for you as it is to run a car.

I had only two basic non-negotiables: the majority of my pocket money for good groceries, so I could eat as well as possible; and a little set aside to be social with friends, including two coffees a week.

The Pocket Money Savings Plan shopping list

- Groceries
- Takeaway coffee
- Toiletries and medicines
- Petrol
- Public transport and/or parking meter fees
- Entertainment

Groceries – about \$80

Feeding yourself well is one of life's simple luxuries – don't scrimp, but be smart.

If you're single, aim to cook three dishes that each serve four, supplying 12 meals for your week, six lunches and six dinners. And if you go out, you can roll over those meals to the next week and save even more.

Organise your fridge and freezer so you can see what you have. Celebrity chef Jamie Oliver recommends freezing food flat – for example, portions of pasta sauce or casserole in squashed sheets – to prevent overshopping, and so you can defrost quickly when you're exhausted after work. It's a simple trick that has changed how long I can stretch the use of my groceries.

A typical weekly meal plan for me is a combination of three of these cheap go-to recipes, which I've included under my 'fiscal finest menu' in Step 2, 'How to Be a Cheapskate and Keep Your Friends':

- Cheapskate carbonara
- Lovely low-cost mussels
- Homemade minestrone soup and a bread roll
- Zucchini spaghetti with bolognese sauce